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THOUGH HE WAS TOLD THAT 35 MLAS WERE DEEPLY UNPOPULAR, KCR DID NOT HEED THE WARNING. ALL BUT A HANDFUL OF SITTING LAWMAKERS GOT TICKETS

For instance, in Malkajgiri, debutant Marri Rajashekar Reddy defeated M. Hanumantha Rao, the incumbent BRS MLA, who had joined the Congress after KCR denied a ticket to his son.

Mention must also be made of the Opposition's allegations about the stranglehold of KCR's family over the BRS—son K.T. Rama Rao and nephew T. Harish Rao were ministers, while daughter K. Kavitha is an MLC. Kavitha's alleged involvement in the Delhi excise corruption case also attracted negative attention. The Congress gleefully turned all of this to its advantage. Apart from anti-incumbency, voter fatigue and dissatisfaction among the youth, largely for want of adequate government job opportunities, contributed to the Congress win.

Muslims outside Hyderabad were persuaded to vote for the Congress, and so were Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and the influential Reddys. Muslims, who have a sizeable presence in 45 constituencies, had traditionally backed the Congress but shifted to the BRS in 2014 and 2018. A massive outreach in the past few months helped regain their support. This is why 14 of the 19 newly-elected SC MLAs and nine of the 12 ST MLAs are from the Congress and account for a third of its tally. But none of the six Muslim candidates fielded by the Congress nor the three fighting on the BRS ticket managed to win.

"The BRS's strategies for managing people have failed," says Telangana Jana Samithi president M. Kodandaram. "It has paid for intolerance against criticism and for arrogance. This should serve as an example for future leaders on how people are vital in a democracy." The Congress, on its part, did not rely on anti-incumbency against the BRS to do the work, it acted on a carefully crafted game plan. Credit for this ground offensive goes to the feisty 54-year-old A. Revanth Reddy, who was appointed Telangana Pradesh Congress Committee (TPCC) president in June 2021 (see *Turnaround Man*). Reddy energised the Congress challenge by starting to target KCR directly on matters like governance, nepotism and corruption. Congress defeats in bypolls and initial challenges to his leadership from within couldn't deter him. Backed by party bosses in Delhi, Reddy's full-blooded aggression proved to be the clincher for the Congress. "For KCR, Telangana means his family. For the Congress, it means four crore people," he says, by way of explanation for the BRS's defeat.

THE TASK BEFORE THE CONGRESS

Now that the battle is won, the immediate challenge for the Congress is to start delivering on the 'six guarantees' it has promised to the people of Telangana and launch a caste survey as a precursor to increased reservation for backward classes. Implementing the guarantees involves a large outflow from the state exchequer. However, maintaining fiscal prudence is a tough ask, considering the BRS has in recent years overleveraged the state economy. This could force the Congress government to run a tight ship fiscally.

Public debt, too, is a worrying matter. At the end of 2023-24, Telangana's outstanding liabilities are projected to be 23.8 per cent of its GSDP (gross state domestic product), slightly lower than the revised estimate for 2022-23. The debt mobilisation target for the current financial year is Rs 38,234 crore. The state government has already mobilised Rs 33,378 crore in the first half of the financial year itself. And the BRS government has almost fully exhausted the debt access limits, according to the Comptroller and Auditor General of India data.

While marshalling resources is a challenge, the Congress has to brace for the bigger political challenge and try to make gains in the upcoming parliamentary polls. Going by the 2023 assembly poll statistics, the Congress could win nine of the 17 Lok Sabha seats, compared to the three it won in 2019. The BJP, poised to grow substantially at the cost of the BRS, is expected to be a tough adversary not merely in the Greater Hyderabad region but also in north Telangana. "The Congress will have to immediately fulfil its election promises like the six guarantees and take up the caste survey. Otherwise, it will run into rough weather in the Lok Sabha poll," warns Venkatesu. Vageeshan stresses that now that it is in power, the Telangana Congress must function efficiently in preparing for the polls. The new ruling party has plenty on its plate. ■